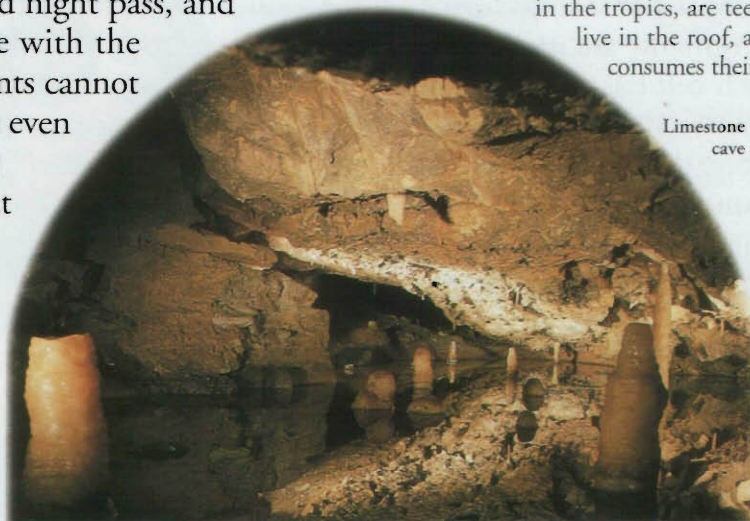


CAVE WILDLIFE



A DEEP CAVE is a world of its own, with conditions far removed from those outside. Deep within a cave there is no light at all.

No day and night pass, and temperatures change little with the seasons. Without light plants cannot grow, yet animal life exists even here. Some creatures enter caves for shelter or to hunt for prey; others spend their entire lives in this dark, dank environment and have adapted to move about and sense food in the dark.



Limestone cave

Plants

No plants can grow deep in a cave due to lack of light. But the cave entrance is often framed by a fringe of plants, such as liverworts, mosses, ferns, and algae, that have adapted to damp, shady conditions. Many of these plants grow without soil, sending out small roots that grip the bare rock.



Invertebrates

Caves are often full of invertebrate life. Beetles, spiders, snails, worms, and crayfish survive in large numbers in caves. They feed on debris brought in by running water or dropped by animals that feed outside.



Cave cricket

Scavenging cave crickets use their long, wiry antennae to feel their way past objects in the dark and towards food on the cave floor. Alert for the merest brush against them, they try to out-manoeuvre prey such as cave centipedes. Cave crickets, like cockroaches and other invertebrates, feed on debris dropped by bats and cave birds. They also eat the fallen carcasses of these animals when they die.

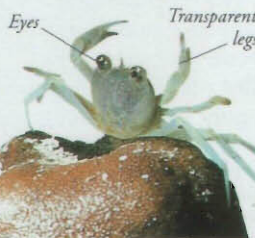
New Zealand glow-worm

These glow-worms are gnat larvae that live at the entrances to caves. They have evolved an ingenious method of catching food. The larvae spin dangling sticky threads that they illuminate with a light produced from their own bodies. In the darkness of a cave, the glowing threads lure and ensnare small flying insects that the larvae haul up and devour.

Larvae hauling up an insect.



Trapped insect



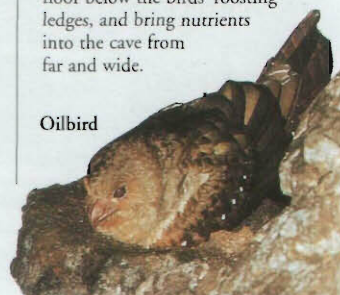
Cave crab

Tropical caves are often home to some small species of crab that use their pincers to pick food debris from underground streams or the cave floor. Like many cave dwellers – among them millipedes, spiders, salamanders, and shrimps – cave crabs are ghostly pale in colour. In the total darkness of deep caves, skin pigmentation is of no value. Some animals also lose their sight due to the lack of natural light.

Birds

Some birds, such as barn owls and swifts, make nests within caves. The oilbird of South America nests deep within caves and uses rapid tongue clicks to navigate by echolocation. Colonies of oilbirds fly outside the cave at night to feed on fruit in the surrounding forests. The birds' droppings litter the cave floor below the birds' roosting ledges, and bring nutrients into the cave from far and wide.

Oilbird



Mammals

Some mammals make temporary or permanent homes in caves. The American black bear sometimes shelters in caves during the winter months, as do some foxes. Many species of bat roost, rear their young, or hibernate in the security of caves, some forming colonies thousands strong. Hanging from the roof by their hind feet, the bats are out of reach of almost all predators.

Lesser horseshoe bat

The lesser horseshoe bat is found in large numbers in caves all over Europe, Asia, and northern Africa, where it hibernates during the winter months. Like other bats, it navigates in the dark by using echolocation. It emits high-pitched calls and listens for the echoes that bounce back from the cave walls, stalactites, and other obstructions.

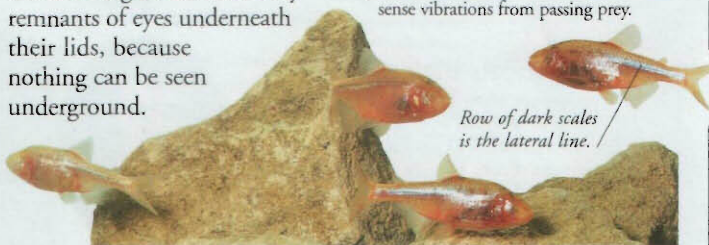


Fish

A number of fish species have adapted to living in subterranean streams that flow inside cave systems throughout the world. Most are sightless, with only remnants of eyes underneath their lids, because nothing can be seen underground.

Blind cave characin

Sightless cave animals compensate for their lack of vision with a highly refined sense of touch. Most fish have a lateral line along their sides – a row of sense organs containing nerve endings. The blind cave characin of Mexico has a very prominent lateral line with which it can sense vibrations from passing prey.



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